

REVISION SHEET: Ethnic & Linguistic Elements in Indian Population

ANTHROPOLOGY P1 • UNITS 1.9, 1.10 • L-21 SARRTHI IAS • EXAM-READY REVISION

1. KEY POINTS — Rapid Recall

A. Racial / Ethnic Classification

- Three major classifications: **Risley** (1915, 7 types, nasal index) → **Guha** (1931 Census, 6 types, most accepted) → **Sarkar** (1954, 6 elements, cephalic index)
- Risley was the **first to scientifically classify** Indian races. He was **Census Commissioner 1901**. Used **anthropometric techniques** — especially **nasal index**. He linked **race with caste**.
- Risley's 7 types: Turko-Iranian, Indo-Aryan, Scytho-Dravidian, Aryo-Dravidian, Mongolo-Dravidian, Mongoloid, Dravidian
- Guha's classification is **most widely accepted**. Based on **anthropometric surveys preceding 1931 Census**. Founded on firm scientific evidence. 6 broad types with ~14 sub-types.
- Guha's 6 types: Negrito, Proto-Australoid, Mongoloid (Palaeo + Tibeto), Mediterranean (Paleo + Med + Oriental), Western Brachycephals (Alpinoid + Dinaric + Armenoid), Nordic
- Guha's **key finding**: Brachycephals (broad-headed) dominate Indian population — this was **not widely held before Guha**.
- Sarkar used **cephalic index** (head shape). Said India was predominantly **dolichocephalic** (long-headed) — **directly contradicting Guha**.
- Sarkar **denied Negrito presence** in India based on his Kadar study (1959). Many anthropologists disagree.
- Cultural links in Guha**: Mediterranean type → built **Indus Valley Civilization**. Paleo-Mediterranean → introduced **megalithic culture** to India.
- Modern view**: All three classifications are outdated. Today we study **genetics, populations, continuous variation & clines** rather than fixed racial boxes.

B. Linguistic Classification

- 4 language families: **Indo-European (73%)**, Dravidian (20%), Austric/Nishad (1.3%), Sino-Tibetan/Kirat (0.85%)
- Why linguistic diversity? Two reasons: (a) multiple **racial groups** brought own speech, (b) **geographical isolation** (mountains, deserts, forests) allowed separate evolution
- Language gives **regional identity**, sense of belonging, **social & emotional integration**
- 5 bridge languages across history: Sanskrit (ancient) → Tamil (ancient) → Persian (medieval) → Hindi-Urdu (medieval/modern) → English (modern)
- Tamil = one of the **oldest living languages** (2000+ yrs). Sangam literature, Thirukkural. Spoken in 4+ countries.

C. Linguistic Challenges

- Language becomes a **mobilising symbol of identity** in multi-ethnic societies (Paul Brass)
- Anti-Hindi Agitations (TN, 1960s) → DMK rose to power, ended Congress dominance, reshaped Tamil politics permanently
- Gokak Agitation (Karnataka, 1980s) → Demanded Kannada as first language in schools → milestone in Kannada pride
- 8th Schedule demands: Bhojpuri (spoken in 27 countries), Meitei/Manipuri (won recognition 1992, demands classical status)
- Indian modernity **reshapes traditions, does not erase them** — applies to language politics too (Yogendra Singh)

MNEMONIC — Risley's 7 types: "TIS AM MD"

Turko-Iranian, Indo-Aryan, Scytho-Dravidian, Aryo-Dravidian, Mongolo-Dravidian, Mongoloid, Dravidian

MNEMONIC — Guha's 6 types: "NP Mo Me WB No"

Negrito, Proto-Australoid, Mongoloid, Mediterranean, Western Brachycephals, Nordic

MNEMONIC — 4 Language families: "ADSI" (like ADSI cable!)

Austric (1.3%), Dravidian (20%), Sino-Tibetan (0.85%), Indo-European (73%)

2. SCHOLAR TOOLKIT — Every View That Matters

Scholar	View / Contribution	Use When Writing About	Quotable Line
H.H. Risley	First scientific racial classification of India. 7 types using nasal index. Census Commissioner 1901. Published "The Peoples of India" (1915). Linked caste with race.	Racial classification, caste-race link, colonial anthropology	"Classified Indians into seven racial categories using anthropometric techniques"
B.S. Guha	Most widely accepted classification. 6 broad types (~14 sub-types). Based on anthropometric surveys of 1931 Census. Key finding: Brachycephals dominate India.	Any racial diversity Q, ethnic elements, population composition	"The most recognised and acceptable racial classification based on scientific surveys"
S.S. Sarkar (1954)	6 ethnic elements based on cephalic index. Concluded India is predominantly dolichocephalic . Denied Negrito presence (Kadar study 1959). Contradicted Guha on brachycephaly.	Comparison Qs, criticism of Guha, head shape debate	"Contested Guha's brachycephalic dominance, insisting dolichocephaly was the norm"
Malhotra & Vasulu (2019)	Criticized both Risley & Guha: (a) small/inadequate sample size, (b) neglect of environmental factors, (c) questions about tribal group selection	Criticism section of any racial classification answer	"Risley's sample of 42 castes out of 87 was inadequate to represent India's diversity"
Kalla (1994)	Criticized Guha specifically: (a) identification of Negrito elements, (b) attribution of foreign origin to Indian racial types	Guha's criticism, Negrito debate, indigenous vs foreign origin	"Questioned the very identification of Negrito elements and the assumption of foreign origin"
Paul Brass	In multi-ethnic societies, language becomes a mobilising symbol of identity . Language is political, not just cultural.	Linguistic conflicts, identity politics, ethnicity & language	"Language is a mobilising symbol of identity in multi-ethnic societies"
Robert Hardgrave	Anti-Hindi agitations (TN 1960s) permanently reshaped Tamil politics . Brought DMK to power, ended Congress dominance in TN.	Tamil Nadu politics, Hindi imposition, language movements	"The anti-Hindi movement reshaped Tamil politics permanently"
Sanjib Baruah	Assamese linguistic movements shaped Assamese subnationalism . Language pride clashed with minority language rights in Assam.	NE India, subnationalism, Assam, linguistic minorities	"Linguistic movements shaped the very foundation of Assamese subnationalism"
Yogendra Singh	Indian modernity reshapes traditions but does not erase them . Applied to language: regional languages persist despite globalisation & Hindi pressure.	Modernisation & tradition, language survival, social change	"Indian modernity does not erase traditions but reshapes them"
Kuvempu	Renowned Kannada poet. Supported Gokak Agitation (1980s) for Kannada as first language in Karnataka schools.	Karnataka language identity, Gokak movement	—
Dr. Rajkumar	Iconic Kannada actor. Supported Gokak Agitation alongside Kuvempu. Symbol of Kannada cultural pride.	Gokak Agitation, cultural identity & language	—
 Wilhelm von Humboldt	Noted linguist. "Every language is a worldview" — each language offers a unique way of perceiving and understanding the world.	Opening/closing line for any linguistic diversity answer	"Every language is a worldview"
 Jawaharlal Nehru	India is a "composite culture" shaped by many streams. Languages are a living symbol of unity in diversity, not division.	Unity in diversity essays, national integration, composite culture	"India is a composite culture shaped by many streams"
Mahatma Gandhi	Proposed Hindustani (mix of Hindi-Urdu) as national link language due to its wide acceptance and emotional reach among masses.	Hindi-Urdu debate, link language, language & nationalism	"Hindustani as the language of the masses for national integration"
Panini	Author of Ashtadhyayi — the foundational grammar of Sanskrit. Sanskrit acted as bridge language between Indo-European & Dravidian tongues.	Sanskrit's pan-Indian role, ancient linguistic tradition	—

3. EXAMPLES & CASE STUDIES — Grouped by Use

A. Racial Classification Examples

Classification	Type	Example Groups & Where Found
Risley (7)	Turko-Iranian / Indo-Aryan	Pathans (NW India), Rajputs/Khatris/Jats (Punjab-Haryana-Rajasthan)
	Scytho-/Aryo-Dravidian	Marathas (Maharashtra), Brahmins & SCs of UP-Bihar
	Mongoloid / Dravidian	Kinnets, Lepchas, Bhutias (Himalayas); Santhals, Todas, Gonds, Bhils (Central-South India)
Guha (6)	Negrito	Onge, Jarawa (Andaman), Irula, Kadars — earliest inhabitants
	Proto-Australoid	Oraons, Santhals, Mundas (Chota Nagpur) — most Central/South tribes
	Mediterranean (3 sub-types)	Tamil/Telugu Brahmins (Paleo-Med), Nambudiri Brahmins (Med → IVC link), Punjabi Chattris/Pathans (Oriental)
	W. Brachycephals (3 sub-types)	Bania of Gujarat (Alpinoid), Brahmins of Bengal (Dinaric), Parsis of Bombay (Armenoid)
Sarkar (6)	Australoid	Urals, Paniyan, Kadar (South India) — oldest substratum, concentrated in lower castes
	Mundari-speaking	Chota Nagpur, Orissa hills — migrated from east, Mongoloid affinities

B. Linguistic Case Studies

Anti-Hindi Agitations (TN, 1960s) — Hindi imposition triggered massive protests → DMK came to power → Congress dominance ended in TN forever. **Use:** language & identity, federalism, Hindi imposition Qs

Gokak Agitation (Karnataka, 1980s) — Demanded Kannada as first language in schools. Led by poet Kuvempu & actor Dr. Rajkumar. Use: regional language identity, state-level movements
Meitei/Manipuri — 8th Schedule (1992) — Won recognition; now demands classical language status. Use: linguistic recognition movements, NE India
Bhojpuri Movement — Spoken in 27 countries. Demands 8th Schedule status. Use: dialect vs language debate, linguistic politics
Maharashtra — Marathi Mandatory — Marathi compulsory in CBSE/ICSE up to Class 10. Use: state language protection, linguistic federalism
Assam — Assamese Linguistic Pride — Clashed with Bengali & other minority language rights. Use: NE India, subnationalism, linguistic minorities

C. Cultural-Civilizational Examples

Mediterranean Type → Indus Valley Civilization — Guha suggested this type was responsible for building IVC. Use: linking race & civilisation, ancient India
Paleo-Mediterranean → Megalithic Culture — Probably introduced megalithic culture to India. Dravidian speakers of South India. Use: pre-historic cultural diffusion
Tamil Sangam Literature — 2000+ years old, includes Thirukkural. Tamil spoken across 4+ countries. Use: oldest living languages, cultural continuity
Sanskrit as Bridge Language — Connected Indo-European & Dravidian. Produced Ramayana, Mahabharata, Upanishads, Panini's Ashtadhyayi. Use: pan-Indian cultural integration

4. CRITICAL ANALYSIS — Ready to Use in Answers

A. Why All Racial Classifications Are Criticized

Common criticism across all three: (1) Small/biased sample sizes, (2) Over-reliance on single physical trait (nasal index OR cephalic index OR limited anthropometric measures), (3) Indian population is highly mixed due to centuries of migration & intermarriage — rigid "types" oversimplify reality, (4) Greater intra-group diversity than inter-group diversity undermines the very concept of racial types

B. Classification-Specific Criticisms

Scholar	Specific Criticisms	Modern Alternative
Risley	42/87 castes sampled (Malhotra & Vasulu). Linked caste to race — problematic. Ignored environmental factors.	Modern anthropology uses: • Genetic variation • Population genetics • Continuous variation & clines • No fixed racial boxes • DNA studies (mitochondrial, Y-chromosome)
Guha	Negrito identification & foreign origin attribution questioned (Kalla 1994). Tribal group selection criticized (Malhotra & Vasulu). Brachycephalic Mongoloid elements challenged (Sarkar).	
Sarkar	Over-reliance on cephalic index alone. Denied Negrito entirely (Kadar study 1959). Limited data scope vs Guha. 6-type model oversimplifies complex mixtures.	

C. Key Debates You Can Use

Guha vs Sarkar Debate: Guha said brachycephals dominate India → Sarkar insisted dolichocephaly was predominant. This unresolved debate shows the limitation of using single traits for classification.

Negrito Debate: Guha identified Negritos (Andamanese) → Sarkar denied their presence (Kadar study 1959) → Kalla (1994) questioned foreign origin attribution. Many anthropologists still see Negrito traits in coastal groups.

Race-Caste Link (Risley): Risley linked nasal index to caste hierarchy — now seen as scientifically flawed and ideologically colonial. Used to justify caste inequality as "biological."

D. Linguistic Critical Points

Language as both asset & challenge: Asset = literary treasures, civilisational continuity, regional identity. Challenge = identity politics, Hindi imposition conflicts, exclusion of smaller languages, dialect vs language disputes.

Language & Power: 73% speak Indo-European languages → numerical dominance can marginalise Austric (1.3%) and Sino-Tibetan (0.85%) speakers. 8th Schedule has 22 languages — hundreds of others remain unrecognised.

5. PYQ MAPPING — Extra Dimensions for Your Answers

Q-TYPE 1: "Discuss the racial elements in Indian population" / "Ethnic diversity"

Core: Risley → Guha → Sarkar comparison with key findings

Extra dimension: Don't just list types — show how classifications reflect **migration waves** (Negrito = earliest, Proto-Australoid = pre-Aryan, Indo-Aryan = Central Asian migration, Mongoloid = eastern entry). Link to **civilisational development** (Mediterranean → IVC).

Conclude with: Modern shift to genetics & clines. Race is a social construct, not biological reality.

Q-TYPE 2: "Critically examine Guha's racial classification"

Core: 6 types with sub-types, 1931 Census basis, brachycephalic dominance finding

Extra dimension: Why it's "most accepted" (scientific basis, comprehensive surveys) BUT also why it's outdated (Kalla, Malhotra & Vasulu critiques). Compare with Sarkar to show how even "accepted" classifications are contested.

Conclude with: Genetic studies now replace typological approaches. Clines > types.

Q-TYPE 3: "Linguistic elements and their distribution in India"

Core: 4 families with %, regions, examples

Extra dimension: Link linguistic families to **racial elements** (Austric ↔ Proto-Australoid, Dravidian ↔ Mediterranean, Sino-Tibetan ↔ Mongoloid, Indo-European ↔ Nordic/Indo-Aryan). Show how **geography shaped language isolation**. Mention **endangered languages** (UNESCO lists 197 Indian languages as endangered).

Conclude with: Humboldt — "Every language is a worldview"

Q-TYPE 4: "Language and identity politics in India" / "Challenges of linguistic diversity"

Core: Paul Brass theory + all 6 case studies (Anti-Hindi, Gokak, Bhojpuri, Meitei, Maharashtra, Assam)

Extra dimension: Link to **federalism** — States Reorganisation Act 1956 was based on linguistic principle. **Three-language formula** as attempted solution. **NEP 2020** — mother tongue education up to Class 5. 8th Schedule as site of political struggle (22 languages vs hundreds unrecognised).

Conclude with: Yogendra Singh (modernity reshapes traditions) + Nehru (composite culture)

Q-TYPE 5: "Unity in diversity" / "India's composite culture"

Core: Racial diversity (3 classifications show multiple migration waves) + Linguistic diversity (4 families) + Bridge languages binding them

Extra dimension: Use racial diversity as evidence of **centuries of migration and mixing** — India was never "pure." Use linguistic diversity as evidence of **multiple civilisational streams co-existing**. Connect to the idea that diversity itself IS the unity.

Conclude with: Nehru's "composite culture" + languages as "living symbol of unity in diversity"

Q-TYPE 6: "Race and caste — any connection?" (Cross-cutting angle)

Extra dimension from this chapter: Risley explicitly linked race to caste (nasal index varied by caste group). Aryo-Dravidian type found in both Brahmins & SCs — undermines his own race-caste link. Modern genetics (Human Genome Project) shows **no biological basis for race or caste**. Guha's Proto-Australoid found among both tribal and lower-caste groups — suggests social stratification, not biological distinction.

6. MEMORY HOOKS — Quick Recall

Guha's Mediterranean 3 sub-types: "PMO"

Paleo-Med (megalithic culture, Tamil Brahmins), Mediterranean (IVC, Nambudiris), Oriental (convex nose, Punjabi Chattris)

Guha's W. Brachycephals 3 sub-types: "ADA"

Alpinoid (Bania, Gujarat), Dinaric (Bengal Brahmins), Armenoid (Parsis, Bombay)

Sarkar's 6 elements: "AI I MF Mo"

Australoid, Indo-Aryan, Irano-Scythian, Mundari, Far Eastern, Mongolian

Linguistic conflicts — 6 cases: "AAGBMM"

Anti-Hindi (TN), Assam pride, Gokak (Karnataka), Bhojpuri (8th Sched.), Meitei (1992), Marathi mandatory

Bridge languages chronology: "ST PHE"

Sanskrit, Tamil (ancient) → Persian, Hindi-Urdu (medieval) → English (modern)

Critics to remember: "MKS"

Malhotra & Vasulu (2019) → both Risley & Guha

Kalla (1994) → Guha's Negrito

Sarkar → Guha's brachycephaly claim